The Five Kinds of Care, and What to Ask Any of Them

What each kind of care does and doesn't do, in plain words, and the questions that get a straight answer from a community or an agency.

When a family starts looking, the kinds of care arrive as a list of names: home care, adult day, assisted living, memory care, nursing home. Here is what each one is, in one plain line from a public source, with a question to ask when you talk to one. Then five questions that work for any of them.

The definitions are general, and they are for following the conversation. Which kind fits Mom depends on an assessment of her, by the people who do that, not on this page.

The five kinds

Help at home (home care)

Services provided in the home by a paid caregiver or agency: help with personal care such as bathing and dressing, meals, housekeeping, and companionship. It can be a few hours a week or around the clock, and the cost follows the hours. [1]

WRITE DOWN Their answer when you ask: what happens on a day the caregiver can't come?

Adult day program

Daytime care, activities and often meals at a center, so that the family or another caregiver covers mornings, evenings and nights. Some programs include health services. [2]

WRITE DOWN Their answer when you ask: what happens if she needs help with the bathroom or her medications during the day?

Assisted living

A residential living arrangement that provides individualized personal care, help with activities of daily living, help with medications, and services such as laundry and housekeeping. Types and sizes vary, and so do levels of care and services. [1]

WRITE DOWN Their answer when you ask: what would make you say you could no longer care for her here?

Memory care

Specialized care for people with cognitive impairments, often in a secured part of a community with staff trained for it. It may be a free-standing residence or part of an assisted living facility. [3]

WRITE DOWN Their answer when you ask: is the building secured, and what do you do when a resident tries to leave?

Nursing home (skilled nursing facility)

Provides a wide range of health and personal care services, which typically include nursing care, 24-hour supervision, three meals a day and help with everyday activities. [4]

WRITE DOWN Their answer when you ask: who assesses her before admission, and what would make you decline?

Questions that work for any of them

Ask them the same way of a home-care agency, a day program, a community or a nursing home, and write the answers down with the date and the name of who answered.

1. Who is awake and on duty at night, and how quickly do they come when someone needs help?

2. Will you assess her before she starts, and what would make you say you can no longer care for her?

3. What is the full monthly cost, including care fees and extras, and how often has it gone up in the last few years?

4. If her money runs out, can she stay, and on what terms?

5. Which ways of paying do you accept: private pay, long-term care insurance, public programs? For which, and is there a wait?

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines the kinds of care and gives you questions. It doesn't say which kind Mom needs, which place is good, or what any of them will cost her. Which kind of care is right depends on an assessment of the person, by a doctor, a discharge planner or a care professional. What it costs is the next question, and a written quote is the only reliable answer.

Ready for the next step?

You know the kinds of care and what to ask. The care interview is where they become about Mom: it goes through her daily life area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any of these conversations.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The five kinds are defined from the sources below, in general language. The questions are this roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
2. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Housing Options
4. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care